

holds its own identity through numerous extensions that are available through the Mozilla community. Extensions (add-ons to the basic browser) are available in large numbers, and can be downloaded depending on your personal preferences. This gives Firefox great flexibility.

A feature that made this browser a stand-out was tabbed browsing, though Opera users can smugly say they've had it for years! Instead of opening each link in a new page, they can be stacked in the same window, saving heaps of precious desktop space. Though the Mozilla Foundation never claims to have invented this, they have used it to good effect in their browsers.

Firefox is strong on the interface side—it is simple and neat. The buttons are graphically sharp and do not encroach upon screen space. It also has the ability to customise its appearance using skins (a new colour palette and look). So if the default appearance is not to your taste, you can easily install a new skin, which would have a different colour scheme and button design.

Overall, Firefox is a great browser. It's relatively secure and definitely fast. For advanced users, it's a treat because it can always be tweaked. However, to date, it remains CPU-hungry: if you have a relatively old system, it may slow down your computer.

Opera 8.5

Opera quite comfortably lives up to its billing of “the fastest browser on Earth”. Opera software developers are the leaders in technological innovation in this field. They were first ones to introduce what is now called tabbed browsing, which has become a quintessential aspect of a browser.

This browser, currently in version 8.5, is a must-have for advanced users. The number of innovations and useful features that have been crammed into Opera is something that has to be seen to be believed. Its lean size of 4.5 MB is another wonder as it comes packed with a world-class e-mail client. It keeps your desktop unclut-